5. Early Intimations of India as ‘Shendu’ – the Western Realm

Scholars have attempted to find cultural affinities between ancient India and China. The progenitors of the human race in Chinese legends are Fuxi and Nuwa, who are both brother and sister as well as husband and wife. They are represented with human heads and snake bodies, anthropomorphic symbols which are rare in Chinese culture. They appear to have been borrowed from India. In an ancient chronicle, Liezi, [1] there is a saying ascribed to Confucius. When the master was asked about the qualities of a sage, he is quoted as saying:

> There is a sage in the west, under whose rule there is neither administration nor disorder; he says nothing and people get their faith; he preaches nothing and the people practice his teachings. It is a profound state which cannot be called any name.

Confucius was a contemporary of the Buddha, so it seems unlikely that he would have been aware of the latter. While India was identified as a country in the west, one cannot assume that the reference here is to India. Nevertheless, the reference, though cryptic, is intriguing, particularly since it is attributed to Confucius. Later in history, followers of Confucius were severe critics of Buddhist teachings and of the activities of Buddhist monks in China. So it is ironical that the Chinese master himself is quoted as expressing reverence for a non-Chinese wise man.

The earliest documentary references to India emerge during the Han dynasty (206 BCE –220 CE). The Han emperor Han Wudi (141–87 BCE) had dispatched a senior envoy, Zhang Qian, to Central Asia in 138 BCE to the Yuezhi kingdom to the west, to seek an alliance against the Xiongnu tribal confederacy on its borders. The Xiongnu were harassing the Han empire and attacking the caravan trade, and were also in conflict with the Yuezhi, another semi-nomadic ethnic group. The Han envoy Zhang Qian was captured by the Xiongnu and kept in detention for several years. He was finally freed and resumed his travel to the south, but was unsuccessful in